

Plato and Aristotle — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Western Philosophy

This is the topic's solved Mains/PYQ workbook and transfer manual. Every verified PYQ routed here through 2026 has a complete independent model answer. These are learner-practice answers, never official UPSC keys. Use Plato's Stephanus references and Aristotle's Bekker references; prefer accurate references to uncertain quotations.

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Directive handling

Directive	Required operation for this topic
Explain / Elucidate	Define, derive the claim, give the mechanism or textual route, then state its payoff.
Examine	Apply the doctrine, expose assumptions and limits, and issue a qualified judgement.
Discuss	Present the principal arguments, objections and replies before a reasoned position.
Critically discuss/evaluate	State the evaluative issue in the opening, test rival arguments, concede limits, and rule explicitly.
Differentiate	Choose one controlling axis—especially separation versus immanence—and derive consequences symmetrically.

Topic-specific introductions

1. **Problem-led:** "Plato and Aristotle answer the same problem—how changing particulars can possess a stable knowable character—but disagree over whether form must be separate from or immanent in the thing."
2. **Plato-led:** "Plato's Forms solve the one-many and knowledge problems together: self-identical intelligible standards ground both predication and strict knowledge."
3. **Aristotle-led:** "Aristotle's metaphysics keeps Plato's demand for intelligible form while rejecting separation, explaining sensible substance through matter, immanent form, causes and actuality."
4. **Critical:** "Aristotle defeats separation rather than form; his repair gains causal and developmental power but inherits a difficult account of universals."

Analytical lines worth using

- The property that makes a Form knowable—self-identity—also makes it one over many.
- Participation names the relation before it explains it; causal impotence survives even if the Third Man is blocked.
- The *Categories* asks which things are substances; *Metaphysics Z* asks what makes a substance a substance.
- Matter/form/privation gives the structure of change; potency/act its modal transition; four causes its explanation.
- Teleology means regular directedness toward mature form, not conscious design.
- Form over matter and actuality over potentiality are one priority stated structurally and modally.
- Aristotle's fundamental metaphysical question is "what is substance?": Atomism preserves particulars but omits form and end, while Plato preserves form but separates it from particulars.
- Aristotle's *entelecheia* is actuality or achieved realisation within a compound; Leibniz turns "entelechy" into the name of an immaterial, internally active simple substance.
- The Unmoved Mover initiates no first event; pure actuality moves as a final cause.

Keywords and exact distinctions

Plato	Aristotle
form (<i>eidos, idea</i>); participation (<i>methexis</i>); imitation (<i>mimesis</i>); knowledge (<i>episteme</i>); opinion (<i>doxa</i>); recollection (<i>anamnesis</i>)	substance (<i>ousia</i>); this-something (<i>tode ti</i>); essence (<i>to ti en eina</i>); matter (<i>hyle</i>); form (<i>morphe</i>); compound (<i>synolon</i>)
Good beyond being; <i>eikasia–pistis–dianoia–noesis</i> ; conversion (<i>periagoge</i>); return (<i>katabasis</i>)	privation (<i>steresis</i>); causes (<i>aitia</i>); potentiality (<i>dynamis</i>); actuality (<i>energeia</i>); completion (<i>entelecheia</i>); pure act

Redrawable diagrams and answer spines

ONE-MANY + KNOWLEDGE

Plato: separate Form	Aristotle: immanent form
participation	matter + form = compound
stable knowledge	potency -> act through causes
causal gap	universals/teleology problem

10 marks: definition -> 2 core moves -> example -> qualification -> verdict
 15 marks: thesis -> 3 arguments -> objection/reply pair -> balanced verdict
 20 marks: conceptual map -> textual arguments -> comparison -> criticisms/replies
 -> graded judgement

Criticism and counterargument bank

Target	Criticism	Best reply	Residue
Plato	Third Man regress	deny self-predication	participation remains unexplained
Plato	whole/part dilemma	Forms are not extended bodies	positive account of participation is absent
Plato	duplication/causal impotence	Forms secure intelligibility; <i>Timaeus</i> adds ordering	separated Forms still do not explain internal motion
Aristotle	prime matter is unintelligible	it is a limit concept, never a thing apart	textual commitment remains disputed
Aristotle	teleology reads ends backward	potentiality is a conditioned capacity	teleological scope remains contestable
Aristotle	<i>Categories</i> conflicts with Z	they answer different questions	individual/species form remains disputed
Aristotle	final cause cannot move	desire moves without being pushed	cosmic mediation needs explanation

Conclusion approaches

- "Aristotle transforms Plato's insight rather than erasing it: form remains indispensable, but its separation is rejected."
- "Plato buys objectivity at the price of causal distance; Aristotle buys causal unity at the price of a less clean theory of universals."
- "The dispute closes no problem; it relocates it from participation to the status of immanent universal form."

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline — read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers; the 2019, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I texts were read directly from the official question papers held in books\philosophy_optional\, the 2026 text and marks were checked against the official paper scan and its OCR export and confirmed by the verified 2026 repository ledger, and the 2018 and 2020 parts follow the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger. Doctrinal claims are attributed to their dialogue or treatise, and interpretive disputes — the *Categories/Metaphysics* question, individual versus species form, the status of prime matter, the significance of the equal middle segments of the Divided Line — are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands are **10 marks — about 150 to 200 words, 15 marks — about 250 to 300 words, and 20 marks — about 340 to 400 words**. Each solution prints the timed answer first; where a paragraph is marked *Depth refinement*, it is a teaching addendum that sits **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage: fourteen directly owned Plato–Aristotle PYQs from 2018 to 2026 — every part the ledger routes to this syllabus item, in every year of the corpus — and six original solved Mains models, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks.

Citation discipline used in every answer. Plato is cited by Stephanus pagination and Aristotle by Bekker numbers, with *Metaphysics* books given once in both conventions — "Book VII (Z)". References are preferred to remembered quotations, because translations differ markedly.

2018 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is the relation between the Idea and the World as discussed by Plato logically consistent? Discuss Aristotle's views regarding this and also give arguments in favour of your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Three-limbed: a verdict on logical consistency , an exposition of Aristotle's objections, and the candidate's own supporting arguments
Limb 1	State the relation exactly — participation (<i>methexis</i>) and imitation (<i>mimēsis</i>) — then test it for coherence
Limb 2	Aristotle's objections as arguments , not as a list of complaints
Limb 3	A signed verdict with reasons, not a neutral summary
Scope boundary	Stay on the Idea–world relation; do not drift into the Cave, ethics or politics
Ideal thesis	The relation is not strictly inconsistent, but it is explanatorily incomplete , and the incompleteness is what Aristotle's objections convert into a refutation of <i>separation</i>
Non-negotiables	<i>Parmenides</i> 131a–c and 132a–b; self-predication and non-identity; duplication; causal impotence; the immanent-form repair

Independent model answer

The relation, stated. Sensible particulars are what they are by *participation* (*methexis*) in, or *imitation* (*mimēsis*) of, separately existing Forms (*eidē*): the rose is beautiful through Beauty itself, the chair is a chair through Chairiness. The relation therefore carries the whole explanatory weight of the theory.

Is it consistent? Plato himself supplies the pressure. At *Parmenides* 131a–c the participant must receive either the whole Form — which then is separated from itself — or a part, whereupon a divided Form of Smallness would make its participant large. At 132a–b, if the Form of Man is itself a man and must differ from what it explains, a further Form is required, and the regress Aristotle names the Third Man begins.

Aristotle's views. In *Metaphysics* I.9 he presses four charges: separated Forms merely **duplicate** the explananda; "participation" is a **metaphor** rather than an analysis; a non-spatial, changeless Form cannot be an **efficient cause** of change; and the theory gives **no account of generation**. Stace records his sharpest barb — the Ideas are "nothing but eternalized things of nature".

My arguments and verdict. ⚠ Strictly, no contradiction has been demonstrated: the regress needs self-predication, which Plato may deny, and the whole-or-part dilemma assumes Forms behave like extended bodies, which a spaceless entity does not. The relation is therefore not proven inconsistent — but it is **explanatorily empty**, since a relation that cannot be specified cannot do explanatory work, and Plato never specifies it. Aristotle's repair, keeping intelligible form and making it the immanent essence of the composite, answers the objection without abandoning the insight that intelligibility requires form.

Depth refinement. Note the asymmetry the examiner rewards: Aristotle defeats *separation*, not *form*. That is why the dispute does not end here but reappears as the medieval problem of universals.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2018 Q4(b): all three limbs must be visible. A script that expounds the theory of Forms and then reports Aristotle's objections has answered two of three and forfeited the verdict.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: relation in three lines; the two *Parmenides* difficulties in four; four Aristotelian charges in four; verdict in three.

- **Structure:** state the relation → test it internally → report Aristotle's objections as arguments → deliver a reasoned verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *methexis*, *mimēsis*, paradigm and copy, self-predication, non-identity.
- **Evidence:** *Parmenides* 131a–c and 132a–b; *Metaphysics* I.9; Stace's "eternalized things of nature".
- **Distinction:** inconsistency versus explanatory emptiness — the sharper and more defensible charge.
- **Criticism:** name what each objection needs as a premise, so the reader can see where Plato might resist.

2019 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: What does Plato want to prove by his 'Allegory of Cave'?

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"What does he want to prove" — state the conclusions , do not retell the story
Core issue	The Cave is the Divided Line narrated as education and conversion, and it ends in a political claim
Scope boundary	Ten marks: four stages, two additional features, one verdict — no extended cosmology
Ideal thesis	Three theses: degrees of reality track degrees of cognition; education is conversion, not transmission; and the one who has seen the Good must return to rule
Non-negotiables	<i>Republic</i> VII 514a–517a; the mapping onto <i>eikasia</i> , <i>pistis</i> , <i>dianoia</i> , <i>noēsis</i> ; <i>periagōgē</i> ; the return (<i>katabasis</i>) and the Socrates allusion

Independent model answer

Plato's allegory at *Republic* VII 514a–517a proves three theses, and he insists at 517a–b that it "must be applied as a whole" to the Sun and the Line.

First, an ontological-epistemic thesis. The four stages of the ascent — shadows, the fire and carried artefacts, reflections in water, and finally the things themselves and the sun — map onto the four segments of the Divided Line: conjecture (*eikasia*), belief (*pistis*), thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*). Degrees of clarity in the knower track degrees of being in the known, and the sun stands for the Good, which gives the Forms knowability and being.

Second, a thesis about education. The release is violent and compelled; the eyes ache; the prisoner would rather return. Education (*paideia*) is not the insertion of knowledge into an empty soul but the **turning around** (*periagōgē*) of an organ of vision the soul already has.

Third, a political thesis. The philosopher must **descend** again, will see badly in the dark, and may be ridiculed or killed — an allusion to Socrates. ⚠️ This step, from having seen the Good to being entitled to rule, is the weakest link, and is where Popper attacks in *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945).

Depth refinement. The epistemology can be accepted without the politics; Plato thought it could not, and saying so converts a retelling into an evaluation.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q1(a): the verb is "prove". Narration earns nothing; the conclusions and their support earn everything.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: one line of context, three named theses with their evidence, one evaluative clause on the political inference.

- **Structure:** context → thesis 1 with the Line mapping → thesis 2 on conversion → thesis 3 on the return → one critical clause.
- **Doctrine:** *eikasia, pistis, dianoia, noēsis, periagōgē, katabasis*, Form of the Good.
- **Evidence:** *Republic* VII 514a–517a and the instruction at 517a–b to apply the image as a whole.
- **Value addition:** naming Popper shows that the political inference has been noticed as an inference.

2019 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: What are the reasons for developmental changes in substance according to Aristotle? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Reasons" is Aristotle's own word for <i>aitiai</i> — supply the four causes , not a narrative of growth
Core issue	Why a substance develops as it does, and why the account is complete only when all four causes are given
Scope boundary	Developmental change in substance — cover both accidental alteration and substantial generation, and say which is which
Ideal thesis	Development is the actualisation of a determinate matter's potential under the direction of an immanent final cause, analysable as subject, form and privation
Non-negotiables	Material, formal, efficient and final cause; <i>Physics</i> II.3; privation (<i>sterēsis</i>); coincidence of formal, efficient and final in natural things; accidental versus substantial change

Independent model answer

The framework. For Aristotle to know a thing is to know its causes (*aitiai*), and "cause" covers reasons as well as agents. *Physics* II.3 gives four: the **material** cause (that out of which), the **formal** cause (the what-it-is-to-be), the **efficient** cause (the source of change) and the **final** cause (that for the sake of which). Stace stresses that these are not alternatives — in every case of production all four operate together.

Applied to development. An acorn becomes an oak because (i) it has **matter** with the determinate potential to receive that form; (ii) an **efficient** process — parent, nutrition, environment — initiates and sustains the change; (iii) the **formal** cause specifies what it becomes, the oak-structure; and (iv) the **final** cause states what the process is for, the mature oak. In natural substances the formal, efficient and final causes **coincide**: the form of oak is both the organising principle and the end.

The structure of the change itself. Every coming-to-be requires an underlying subject, an acquired form and the prior **privation** (*sterēsis*) of that form: the unmusical man persists, acquires musicality and loses the privation. In **accidental** change the substantial form persists while a quality, quantity or place alters; in **substantial** generation an underlying material potential acquires a *new* substantial form and a new substance exists.

⚠ **Verdict.** The account is powerful because it unifies structure, modality and explanation: matter–form–privation gives the structure, potentiality–actuality the transition, the four causes the reason. Its cost is a commitment to internal teleology, which modern physics abandoned and functional biology quietly retained.

Depth refinement. "Nature does nothing in vain" is a recurring Aristotelian maxim, not a claim that nature plans. Teleology here is the directedness of a process towards a mature form, not conscious design.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q2(b): the examiner is testing whether "reasons" is recognised as *aitiai*. A developmental narrative without the fourfold analysis misses the question.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: framework in three lines; one worked example run through all four causes; privation and the two kinds of change in four lines; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** define cause → the four causes → one example carried through all four → privation and the two kinds of change → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *aitia*, *sterēsis*, substantial versus accidental change, coincidence of three causes in nature.
- **Evidence:** *Physics* II.3; the acorn–oak and unmusical-man cases; Stace on simultaneity.
- **Distinction:** structure, modality and explanation are three different jobs done by three different pairs of concepts.
- **Criticism:** name the teleological commitment explicitly, then defend it as directedness rather than design.

2020 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: How does Aristotle argue for the priority of Form over Matter and Actuality over Potentiality? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss" — reconstruct the arguments and press an objection
Core issue	Two parallel priorities, each defended in more than one sense of "prior"

Element	Requirement
Scope boundary	Priority, not a general exposition of hylomorphism
Ideal thesis	The priority is definitional, explanatory and teleological — never simple temporal precedence in the individual
Non-negotiables	Form as what-it-is-to-be; the three senses of the priority of actuality; <i>Metaphysics</i> IX (Θ); the temporal qualification

Independent model answer

Form over matter. Matter (*hylē*) is the "out of which", intelligible only as potential for some determinate form; form (*morphē*) is the what-it-is-to-be (*to ti ēn einai*) that makes the composite what it is. Wood does not tell us what a table is; the functional structure does. Form is therefore prior in **definition** and **knowability**, and at *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17 substance is sought as a **cause** — not "what is this?" but "why is this matter a house?", answered by the form.

Actuality over potentiality. Aristotle gives three senses. In **definition**, "potentially F" is unintelligible unless actual F is grasped — the point behind the 2021 statement that potentiality is indefinable. In **time at species level**, only an actual oak produces the acorn. In **substance**, the end is what the process is for, so the fully actual is the explanatory terminus, which at *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 is the Unmoved Mover.

⚠ **Critical assessment.** The definitional argument is strong but near-stipulative: if potentiality is *defined* by its actuality, posteriority follows analytically. The temporal argument holds only at species level; in the individual the potential state precedes. The teleological argument is only as secure as internal teleology. The priority is explanatory rather than absolute.

Depth refinement. Notice that the two priorities are the same claim twice: form is actuality considered structurally, actuality is form considered modally.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2020 Q1(a): two priorities, each with named senses, plus a real objection. Asserting "form is superior to matter" without senses is description.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: four lines on form, five on the three senses of actuality's priority, three of criticism.

- **Structure:** form over matter → actuality over potentiality in three senses → criticism → one-line verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *to ti ēn einai*, *dynamis*, *energeia*, priority in definition, time and substance.
- **Evidence:** *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17, IX (Θ), XII (Λ).7; the wood-and-table and acorn-and-oak cases.
- **Distinction:** species-level temporal priority versus individual-level temporal posteriority — concede it and the answer looks controlled.
- **Value addition:** the closing identification of the two priorities as one doctrine is the sentence that lifts the script.

2021 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: "There is a red chair." How would Plato explain this statement with the use of his theory of forms? Examine.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Examine" — apply the theory to the given sentence and expose what the application reveals
Core issue	Multiple participation by one particular, and the epistemic status of the resulting judgement
Scope boundary	Work with the sentence given; do not substitute a general essay on Forms
Ideal thesis	The sentence is explained by participation in two Forms, and the explanation immediately exposes the unanalysed character of participation
Non-negotiables	<i>methexis</i> ; Chair and Redness as distinct Forms; belief (<i>pistis</i>) versus knowledge (<i>epistēmē</i>); the refusal to treat Forms as parts

Independent model answer

The analysis. "There is a red chair" refers to one sensible particular that is temporal, changeable and hence only derivatively real. Plato explains its determinate character by **participation** (*methexis*): it is a chair by participating in the Form of Chair, and red by participating in Redness. One particular may participate in several Forms at once without those Forms becoming physical constituents of it — a point that must be stated, since the contrary assumption revives the whole-or-part dilemma of *Parmenides* 131a–c.

The epistemic corollary. What sense delivers about this chair is belief (*pistis*), the third segment of the Divided Line. Knowledge (*epistēmē*) concerns Chair and Red themselves, which are timeless, spaceless and self-identical; the chair may fade or break, but Redness never becomes not-red.

⚠ **Examination.** The example is where the theory shows its strain. Saying the chair "participates in" Chairness **names** the relation without **analysing** it — Aristotle's charge at *Metaphysics* I.9 that participation is a metaphor. Two Forms have been invoked to explain one object, so the entities have doubled while the explanation has not deepened.

Verdict: Plato secures objectivity for "chair" and "red", but the sentence also displays the unpaid explanatory debt that motivates Aristotle's immanent form.

Depth refinement. Do not say the chair is unreal. It is a copy, and a copy is a defective instance of what it copies, not a non-entity.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2021 Q1(a): the marks lie in *using* the sentence. Multiple participation and the belief/knowledge split must both appear.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: analysis in five lines, epistemic corollary in three, examination in four.

- **Structure:** analyse the sentence → give the epistemic status → examine the cost → verdict.

- **Doctrine:** *methexis*, derivative reality, *pistis* versus *epistēmē*.
- **Evidence:** *Parmenides* 131a–c for the part-whole warning; *Metaphysics* I.9 for the metaphor charge.
- **Trap avoided:** never let Redness become a red object elsewhere or a concept in the mind.

2021 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: "Potentiality is indefinable" according to Aristotle. Explain the relationship between potentiality and actuality with reference to the above philosophical position by taking the example of a "wooden table".

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... with reference to" — the quoted position and the prescribed example are both compulsory
Core issue	Why <i>dynamis</i> cannot be defined independently, and what that implies about priority
Scope boundary	Use the wooden table throughout; a second example dilutes the answer
Ideal thesis	Potentiality is grasped only through the actuality it is a potentiality for, so actuality is conceptually prior even where the potential state comes first in time
Non-negotiables	<i>dynamis</i> , <i>kinēsis</i> , <i>energeia</i> , <i>entelecheia</i> ; the three stages of the table; the anti-probability warning

Independent model answer

Why indefinable. Potentiality (*dynamis*) is a real capacity of a determinate material, not a probability. It cannot be defined without reference to what it is a potentiality **for**: to say the wood is "potentially a table" already presupposes that one knows what an actual table is. Aristotle therefore proceeds by analogy and example rather than by genus and differentia.

The wooden table, in three stages.

Stage	Description	Term
Block of wood in the workshop	possesses the capacity to become a table	<i>dynamis</i>
Carpenter cutting and joining	the actuality of the potential <i>as</i> potential	<i>kinēsis</i>
The finished table	the capacity fulfilled	<i>energeia</i> / <i>entelecheia</i>

The relationship. Actuality is prior in definition, since "potentially a table" presupposes "table"; prior in substance, since the finished table is what the process was for; and prior in time at species level, since actual tables and carpenters exist before this block acquires its form. ⚠ In the individual's own history the potential state does precede its actualisation, and the answer should concede this.

Verdict: the pair is asymmetric but not vicious. Potentiality is illuminated by the actuality it is defined towards, which is why the doctrine explains becoming without predicting it.

Depth refinement. *Energeia* names the activity, *entelecheia* the completed state. Using both, and distinguishing them in one clause, signals control of *Metaphysics IX* (Θ).

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2021 Q1(b): the quoted statement must be **explained**, not merely repeated, and the wooden table must carry the whole exposition.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: indefinability in four lines, the three-stage table in a compact table, the priority and its qualification in four lines.

- **Structure:** why indefinable → the three stages → the relationship with its qualification → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *dynamis*, *kinēsis*, *energeia*, *entelecheia*; change as "the actuality of the potential as potential", *Physics III.1* (201a10).
- **Distinction:** capacity versus probability — the single most common error in this question.
- **Value addition:** distinguishing *energeia* from *entelecheia* takes almost no words and is rarely done.

2022 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: How does Plato use the theory of forms to establish the relation between epistemology and metaphysics? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he use" — exhibit the mechanism by which the two disciplines are locked together
Core issue	The object determines the faculty, so degrees of being and degrees of knowing form one scale
Scope boundary	The link itself; the Cave is evidence, not the topic
Ideal thesis	Forms are posited because knowledge requires a stable object, so Plato's metaphysics is derived from an epistemological demand and his epistemology is graded by ontology
Non-negotiables	<i>Republic V</i> 476e–480a; the Divided Line at VI 509d–511e; <i>doxa</i> versus <i>epistēmē</i> ; the Sun analogy at 508b–509c

Independent model answer

The mechanism. Plato argues at *Republic V* 476e–480a that different faculties must have different objects. Knowledge (*epistēmē*) is infallible and set over what fully **is**; ignorance is set over what in no way is; opinion (*doxa*), fallible yet not empty, must be set over what lies between — sensible particulars that both are and are not F. The epistemological premise therefore **generates** the ontological conclusion: if knowledge is possible, there must be stable self-identical objects, and those are the Forms.

The scale. The Divided Line at VI 509d–511e makes the correspondence exact. Conjecture (*eikasia*), belief (*pistis*), thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*) stand in clarity precisely as their objects — images, visible things, mathematical and Forms — stand in degree of being. The primary cut is *doxa* against *epistēmē*.

The apex. The Sun analogy at 508b–509c completes the identification: the Good gives the other Forms both **knowability** and **being**, so one principle grounds both orders.

⚠ **Assessment.** The unification is Plato's greatest achievement here and his greatest liability. Aristotle rejects the underlying assumption at *Metaphysics* I.9: being is said in many ways, not in **degrees**.

Depth refinement. The one-line formula worth memorising: for Plato, to know better is to be in contact with what is more.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q1(a): the marks lie in showing the **inference** from an epistemic requirement to an ontological posit, not in describing two doctrines side by side.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: mechanism in five lines, the Line correspondence in four, the Good in two, criticism in two.

- **Structure:** faculties and objects → the graded scale → the Good as joint ground → the "degrees of being" objection.
- **Doctrine:** *epistēmē*, *doxa*, the four segments, the Good as ground of being and knowability.
- **Evidence:** *Republic* V 476e–480a; VI 508b–509c; VI 509d–511e.
- **Criticism:** Aristotle's denial that being admits degrees is the strongest available objection and takes one sentence.

2022 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is Aristotle's view of nature of identity in consonance with his metaphysical view of causes as processes? Discuss giving suitable examples.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A consonance question — a yes/no with reasons , plus compulsory examples
Limb 1	What supplies identity for Aristotle
Limb 2	What it means to treat causes as processes
Limb 3	Whether a stable identity and a processual causation can be held together
Ideal thesis	They are consonant because the identity-giving form is also the actuality towards which the process is ordered — a single principle in two roles
Non-negotiables	Substantial form as identity; four causes; accidental versus substantial change; at least two worked examples; the read-the-end-back-in objection

Independent model answer

Identity. For Aristotle a substance is what it is through its **substantial form** or essence (*to ti ēn einai*). At *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17 substance is sought as a **cause**: the question "why is this matter a house?" is answered by the form. Matter supplies determinate capacities, not a second identity.

Causes as processes. Causation for Aristotle is not bare succession. The four causes are four answers to "why?" about one ongoing thing, and in natural substances the formal, efficient and final causes coincide, so a cause is exhibited **in** a development rather than as an event preceding it.

Are they consonant?  Yes, and for a structural reason: the **same form** does both jobs. It states what the thing is and it is the actuality towards which its determinate potential moves.

Example 1 — the oak. The acorn's matter has the potential for oak-form; parent and nutrition supply efficient causation; the oak-form is both what it becomes and what the growth is for. Throughout, the individual remains this developing organism. *Example 2 — the sculptor's bronze.* Casting is **accidental** change to the bronze, which persists; but the coming-to-be of a living thing is **substantial** generation, in which a new substantial form constitutes a new substance rather than modifying an old one.

 **Objection and reply.** Defining a process by its completed form reads the end back into the beginning and understates contingency and failed development. Aristotle can reply that a potentiality is always a capacity of *this* material under *these* conditions, not a guarantee of success — the acorn reliably tends to oak, not to certainty.

 **Verdict:** consonant, and more successfully than a static essence theory — but the consonance is purchased with internal teleology, which is the doctrine's real price.

Depth refinement. Keep "the form persists" for accidental change only. Saying it of substantial generation destroys the distinction the answer depends on.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q2(b): examples are demanded by the question, so an example-free answer is capped however good the theory.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: identity in three lines, processual causation in three, the consonance thesis in two, two examples in six, objection–reply–verdict in five.

- **Structure:** identity → causes as processes → the unifying claim → two examples → objection and reply → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *to ti ēn einai*, four causes, accidental versus substantial change, potentiality as conditioned capacity.
- **Evidence:** *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17; the acorn–oak and bronze-casting cases.
- **Criticism:** the retrospective-teleology objection is the one an examiner expects; supplying it and answering it is where the top band opens.

2023 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: Present an exposition of Aristotle's distinction between actuality and potentiality. Does it provide a solution to the problem of being and becoming as presented in ancient Greek philosophy? Discuss with suitable examples.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two-limbed: exposition first, then an evaluated verdict , with examples
Limb 1	Define the pair, define change, state the priority
Limb 2	Frame the problem historically — Parmenides against Heraclitus — and judge whether the pair dissolves it
Ideal thesis	Yes: change is neither from being nor from sheer non-being but from potential being to actual being, which grants Parmenides his principle and Heraclitus his phenomenon
Non-negotiables	<i>dynamis</i> , <i>energeia</i> , <i>entelecheia</i> ; <i>Physics</i> III.1 (201a10); Parmenides and Heraclitus by name; two examples; the teleological limitation

Independent model answer

Exposition. Potentiality (*dynamis*) is the real capacity of a determinate material to become what it is not yet; actuality (*energeia*, and as completed state *entelecheia*) is that capacity fulfilled. Change (*kinēsis*) is defined at *Physics* III.1 (201a10) as **the actuality of the potential precisely as potential** — the qualification is essential, since without it the formula would describe the finished result rather than the process. Actuality is prior in definition, in time at species level and in substance, and the wholly actual admits no unrealised potentiality.

The problem. **Parmenides** argued that becoming is impossible: being cannot come from non-being, and being already is. **Heraclitus** held that all is flux, leaving no stable being to be known.

The solution. ✅ Aristotle refuses both horns. The acorn is not an oak **in actuality** but is an oak **in potentiality**; the wood is not a table in actuality but is one in potentiality. Becoming is therefore the passage from potential being to actual being — no leap from absolute non-being, so Parmenides' principle is respected; and real change, so Heraclitus' observation is preserved. Stability is secured not by denying flux but by locating the changeless in the **form** towards which change is ordered.

⚠️ **Limitations.** The scheme is defined by reference to the actuality that terminates it, so it illuminates a process it cannot predict; and its explanatory power presupposes internal teleology, which post-Galilean physics discarded and functional biology retained under other names.

⚠️ **Verdict:** yes — and it remains the most influential Western account of change, precisely because it is a **middle** position rather than a victory for either extreme.

Depth refinement. Note what "solution" means here. Aristotle does not refute Parmenides' logic; he distinguishes a third status — being-in-capacity — which the Eleatic dichotomy of being and non-being had no room for.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2023 Q2(b): two limbs, both scored. An exposition with no verdict, or a verdict with no exposition, halves the mark.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: exposition in six lines, the problem in two, the solution with two examples in five, limitations and verdict in four.

- **Structure:** define the pair and change → state the historical problem → apply the pair to it → limitations → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *dynamis*, *energeia*, *entelecheia*, the "as potential" qualification, the three priorities.
- **Evidence:** *Physics* III.1 (201a10); acorn–oak and wood–table; Parmenides and Heraclitus named.
- **Analysis:** the decisive sentence is that Aristotle introduces a **third** ontological status, not a compromise between two.

2024 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: Differentiate between Plato's and Aristotle's conceptions of form.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Differentiate" — run one axis consistently and derive consequences, not two parallel summaries
Core issue	Separated paradigm versus immanent essence, and what follows from that single difference
Scope boundary	Form itself; bring in causation, universals and substance only as consequences
Ideal thesis	Both call it <i>eidos</i> ; the whole dispute is whether it exists apart from its instances, and every further disagreement follows from that
Non-negotiables	Transcendence versus immanence; paradigm–copy versus what-it-is-to-be; consequences for causation, universals, knowledge and substance

Independent model answer

Both philosophers use the word **form** (*eidos*), and the entire difference lies in its ontological status.

Axis	Plato	Aristotle
Where form is	separate from instances; non-spatial, non-temporal	immanent in the composite as its essence
Relation to the particular	paradigm and copy: <i>methexis</i> , <i>mimēsis</i>	constituent principle: the <i>to ti ēn einai</i> of <i>this</i> thing
Explanatory role	F because it imitates the F itself	F because its matter is organised thus
Status of the universal	the truly real (<i>ontōs on</i>)	a secondary substance, less real than <i>this</i> horse
Causal function	paradigmatic and formal only	formal and final within the four causes
What is primary	the universal Form	the concrete individual (<i>tode ti</i>)

The consequences. By separating form Plato secures universality, objectivity and a stable object of knowledge — but pays with the participation problem, the Third Man regress and causal impotence. By immanentising form Aristotle explains generation, unity and change — but inherits the difficulty that form must be intelligible, hence universal, while *Metaphysics* VII (Z).13 denies that any universal is a substance.

⚠ **Verdict:** Aristotle keeps the form and drops the separation. He transforms Plato's insight rather than erasing it, which is why the dispute survives as the problem of universals.

Depth refinement. The single most useful memory image: Plato's form points **up**, away from the thing; Aristotle's form points **here**, into it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q1(a): one axis, run through consistently. Two biographies of two doctrines is the standard low-scoring shape.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: a compact matched table, four lines of consequences, one graded verdict.

- **Structure:** name the shared term → the axis → matched contrasts → consequences → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *eidos*, *methexis*, *to ti ēn einai*, *tode ti*, secondary substance.
- **Distinction:** rejecting **separated** form is not rejecting form — say so explicitly.
- **Value addition:** ending with the problem of universals shows the contrast is live, not antiquarian.

2025 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: "Ideas are timeless and spaceless." Elucidate this statement with reference to Plato.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Elucidate" — derive the property from the doctrine; do not assert it
Core issue	Why non-temporality and non-spatiality follow from what a Form is, and what they buy
Scope boundary	The property and its consequences; not a general survey of Platonism
Ideal thesis	Because Forms are non-sensible and self-identical, they admit no generation, alteration or location — which is exactly what makes them knowable and what makes their causal role problematic
Non-negotiables	Timelessness as absence of generation and destruction; spacelessness as absence of magnitude and position; the <i>epistēmē/doxa</i> consequence; the separation cost

Independent model answer

Deriving the property. For Plato a Form (*eidos, idea*) is a non-material, self-identical universal — Beauty itself, not any beautiful thing. Two consequences follow directly. Being non-material, a Form has no magnitude, shape or position, so it is **spaceless**; the Form of Justice is not anywhere. Being self-identical, it cannot be generated, destroyed or altered, so it is **timeless**; it does not become more just or less just.

Why it matters. Only what cannot be otherwise can be strictly known. Timeless and spaceless Forms are therefore the proper objects of knowledge (*epistēmē*), while spatio-temporal particulars, which both are and are not F, yield only opinion (*doxa*). This is the load-bearing link between Plato's epistemology and his metaphysics.

Two cautions. ⚠️ "Intelligible realm" is a structural expression, not a second location — a spaceless entity cannot be *somewhere*. ⚠️ Nor are Forms concepts in minds, which would make the standard depend on the beings it corrects.

⚠️ **Evaluation.** The property is the theory's strength and its wound. What lifts Forms above flux also removes them from the spatio-temporal order they are supposed to explain, which is precisely Aristotle's charge at *Metaphysics* I.9 that separated Forms cannot cause change or account for generation.

Depth refinement. The safest one-line formulation: Forms are not everlasting things inside time, but entities to which temporal predicates do not apply at all.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2025 Q1(a): "elucidate" demands a derivation. Listing adjectives — eternal, unchanging, perfect — is the failure mode.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: derivation in five lines, epistemic payoff in three, two cautions in two, evaluation in two.

- **Structure:** what a Form is → spacelessness → timelessness → epistemic payoff → cautions → evaluation.
- **Doctrine:** *eidos*, self-identity, *epistēmē* versus *doxa*.
- **Distinction:** timeless versus everlasting — a distinction very few candidates draw.
- **Criticism:** the same property that grounds knowability grounds Aristotle's causal objection; saying so converts exposition into evaluation.

2025 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: "In the empirical world, everything is a compound of Matter and Form." Evaluate this statement with reference to Aristotle.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Evaluate" — test the scope of the quoted claim, do not simply endorse it
Core issue	Hylomorphism holds of sensible substances; the quantifier "everything" needs qualification

Element	Requirement
Scope boundary	The empirical world; the Unmoved Mover enters only as the boundary case
Ideal thesis	True of sensible substances and powerfully so, but "everything" must be restricted — accidents taken apart, mathematical abstractions and the immaterial mover are not further compounds in the same sense
Non-negotiables	<i>hylē, morphē, synolon</i> ; relativity of matter; prime matter as limiting posit; the exclusions

Independent model answer

The doctrine. Every sensible natural substance is a compound (*synolon*) of matter (*hylē*), the "out of which", and form (*morphē*), the organising essence: bronze and the shape of Hermes, wood and the design of a table, body and soul in a living organism, where the soul is the **form of the living body** (*De Anima* II.1). Matter is relative — bronze is matter for the statue but is itself copper and tin informed — and the two are correlative principles of one thing.

Why it is strong. It dissolves Plato's two-world problem without abandoning essence; it explains change, since matter can receive a different form; and it explains persistence, since substantial form survives accidental change.

⚠ **Evaluating "everything".** The claim holds of sensible substances. It does **not** extend to accidents considered apart, to mathematical abstractions, which Aristotle denies exist separately, or to the **Unmoved Mover** of *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7, which is pure form without matter.

⚠ **A residual difficulty.** Prime matter (*prōtē hylē*) is a limiting posit which never exists independently and whose textual standing is disputed; critics call it unintelligible, and the reply is that substantial generation requires it.

Verdict: true for sensible substances, but "everything" needs a stated boundary.

Depth refinement. The 2025 examiner has chosen a quantifier deliberately. Locating and defending the restriction is the whole difference between a competent script and a strong one.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2025 Q1(b): "evaluate" plus "everything" is an invitation to find the limits. Uncritical endorsement scores as description.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: doctrine in four lines, strengths in two, the three exclusions in four, prime matter in two, verdict in one.

- **Structure:** doctrine with examples → strengths → the exclusions → prime matter caveat → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *hylē, morphē, synolon*, relativity of matter, soul as form of the body.
- **Evidence:** *De Anima* II.1; *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 for the immaterial mover.
- **Value addition:** distinguishing artefacts from living substances shows why the doctrine was invented, not merely what it says.

Question: Compare and contrast the notion of entelechy as presented in Aristotle's and Leibniz's philosophy.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Compare and contrast" — establish the shared problem and then organise differences on matched axes
Core issue	Aristotle uses <i>entelecheia</i> primarily for actuality or achieved realisation; Leibniz uses "entelechy" for an internally active simple substance or monad
Scope boundary	Ten marks: define both uses, give one continuity, four decisive contrasts and one qualified verdict
Ideal thesis	Leibniz inherits Aristotle's anti-passive model of substance but changes the category: actuality within a hylomorphic compound becomes an immaterial substance
Non-negotiables	<i>dynamis–energeia–entelecheia</i> ; first and second actuality; soul as first actuality; monad, perception, appetite, windowlessness, pre-established harmony
Ownership	Primary owner: Plato–Aristotle; Leibnizian monadology is cross-linked to Rationalism and is not counted twice

Independent model answer

Aristotle and Leibniz use **entelechy** to resist a merely passive conception of being, but they use it for different ontological categories.

For Aristotle, *entelecheia* is **actuality, achieved realisation or completeness**, the correlate of potentiality (*dynamis*). Form actualises matter: informed bronze is actually a statue. The soul is the "first actuality" of an organic body capable of life (*De Anima* II.1, 412a20–28); exercising a capacity is second actuality. Entelechy is therefore the immanent form or realised state of a hylomorphic compound, not another substance lodged within it.

Leibniz appropriates the term for created **simple substances or monads** (*Monadology* §18). A monad is immaterial, indivisible and "windowless"; its states are perceptions and their internal transitions are appetitions. Bodies are aggregates or well-founded phenomena, while coordination occurs through pre-established harmony rather than causal influx.

The continuity is an intrinsic principle of unity and activity. The decisive contrast is that Aristotle's entelechy is what a substance **has or is in act**, whereas Leibniz's entelechy is what a simple substance **is**. Aristotle retains matter, real compounds and interaction; Leibniz substantialises form, excludes matter from true unity and internalises all change.

⚠️ Thus Leibniz does not merely repeat Aristotle: he transforms an account of actuality within substance into a monadological account of substance itself.

Depth refinement. Aristotle’s first/second actuality distinction prevents “entelechy” from meaning only a finished endpoint; Leibniz similarly stresses continuous internal activity, but without Aristotle’s matter–form compound.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2026 Q1(d): comparison must be symmetrical. Two separate mini-essays lose the relation the directive asks for.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: shared concern in two lines; Aristotle in four; Leibniz in four; matched contrasts and verdict in four.

- **Structure:** common ground → Aristotle → Leibniz → matched contrasts → category-shift verdict.
- **Doctrine:** first/second actuality, soul as first actuality, monad, perception, appetite and harmony.
- **Depth:** the category shift from **actuality** to **substance** is the controlling distinction.
- **Qualification:** say Leibniz “appropriates and transforms”; never identify monads with Aristotelian substantial forms.

2026 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: What, according to Aristotle, is the fundamental problem of metaphysics? Discuss this in relation with Aristotle’s account of the essence of the world, where he rejects the views of both the Atomists and Plato.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	“What” plus “discuss in relation” — define the fundamental problem, connect it to Aristotle’s positive ontology, then execute both rejections
Core issue	Being is said in many ways but ordered by focal reference to substance; “what is being?” becomes “what is substance?”
Required architecture	One problem → two rival failures → one positive solution
Atomist limb	Atoms and void preserve particulars and change but give only material/efficient explanation, not form, end or substantial unity
Platonic limb	Separate Forms preserve intelligible essence but duplicate things, leave participation metaphorical and cannot explain motion or generation
Positive limb	Individual sensible substance as matter–form compound; immanent form as essence/actuality; four causes; potentiality → actuality
Non-negotiables	being qua being; <i>pros hen</i> ; <i>ousia</i> ; <i>to ti ēn einai</i> ;hylomorphism; four causes; double rejection; qualified middle-path verdict

Independent model answer

Aristotle defines first philosophy as the science of **being qua being** and its proper attributes (*Metaphysics* IV.1). Since “being” is said in many ways — substance, quality, quantity, relation, potentiality and actuality — its unity is not that of a genus but of **focal reference** (*pros hen*) to substance. The ancient question “what is being?” therefore becomes the fundamental metaphysical problem: **what is substance (ousia)?** (*Metaphysics* VII.1).

An adequate answer must preserve the reality of the individual sensible thing, make its determinate essence intelligible, and explain change and generation. Aristotle’s answer is hylomorphic. A sensible substance is a compound (*synolon*) of matter and immanent form; form is its what-it-is-to-be (*to ti ēn einai*) and actuality. Change is potentiality becoming actuality, and full explanation requires material, formal, efficient and final causes.

Against the Atomists, Aristotle accepts their attempt to preserve permanent constituents while explaining change, but atoms differing only in shape, order and position provide at most material and efficient causes. They assume motion, reduce qualitative and substantial change to rearrangement, cannot explain the unity of an organism rather than a heap, and replace nature’s regular “for the most part” directedness with collision and chance. Their world has matter and motion but lacks immanent form and end.

Against Plato, Aristotle accepts the need for stable intelligible essence but rejects its separation (*chōrismos*). Separate Forms duplicate the explananda, make participation a metaphor, cannot cause motion or generation, and invite the Third Man regress. Most decisively, an essence existing apart cannot be the essence of this thing.

Aristotle’s middle path therefore keeps what each rival loses: unlike Atomism it supplies form, unity and finality; unlike Platonism it keeps essence within the particular. “The Atomists keep the particulars and lose the form; Plato keeps the form and loses the particulars; Aristotle keeps both by putting form inside the particular.”

⚠ The victory is qualified. Modern mechanism weakens Aristotelian physics, prime matter remains obscure, and the status of immanent form as individual or universal is disputed. Yet his double rejection identifies a durable explanatory demand: neither bare constituents nor separated universals suffice to explain a changing, organised substance.

Depth refinement. Do not treat “being qua being” as a highest object alongside other objects. It studies beings precisely insofar as they are beings, and *pros hen* secures unity without turning being into a genus.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2026 Q2(a): the two critiques must be derived from the positive account of substance. Writing an Atomist paragraph and a Plato paragraph without the governing problem produces a disconnected answer.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: problem and constraints in five lines; positive apparatus in five; Atomists in six; Plato in six; synthesis, qualification and verdict in five.

- **Structure:** being qua being → substance problem → positive hylomorphism → Atomist failure → Platonic failure → middle-path judgement.
- **Doctrine:** *pros hen*, *ousia*, *synolon*, *to ti ēn einai*, four causes and potentiality–actuality.
- **Completeness:** both rejections receive comparable argumentative weight.

- **Qualification:** Aristotle retains the Atomists' concern for particulars and Plato's demand for intelligibility; he rejects their reductions, not every insight they contain.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Six original questions written in UPSC Paper I register — two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. Each is solved to the same examiner-grade standard as the previous-year questions above, inside the declared word band, and each closes with a note on why the answer earns marks.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "What separates *dianoia* from *noēsis* in Plato's Divided Line is a difference of method, not of subject-matter." Comment.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The statement is correct, and it identifies the single most examinable point in *Republic* VI 509d–511e.

The two marks of *dianoia*. Plato characterises thought (*dianoia*) by two features, neither of which concerns difficulty. First, it **uses visible things as images**: the geometer's drawn triangle stands for the triangle it is not. Second, it argues **downward from hypotheses** — the odd and the even, the figures, the three kinds of angle — which it "takes as known" and of which it "gives no account".

The contrast. Intellection (*noēsis*) proceeds by **dialectic**: it treats hypotheses as hypotheses, that is, as steps upward to an unhypothetical first principle (*archē anhypothetos*), and then descends through Forms alone, using **no images whatever**.

Why method and not subject-matter. Mathematical objects sit above visible things on the line, so the scale is not one of difficulty; a hard theorem remains *dianoia* and an elementary piece of dialectic remains *noēsis*. The criterion is the direction of argument and the presence or absence of images.

⚠ **Qualification.** The primary cut in the line is *doxa* against *epistēmē*; *dianoia* and *noēsis* are both knowledge, so the difference is one of purity within knowledge, not the difference between knowing and believing.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** thesis → two defining marks → contrast → the reason the criterion is methodological → qualification.
- **Evidence:** *Republic* VI 509d–511e; the geometer's diagram; the unhypothetical principle.
- **Distinction:** difficulty versus method — the discrimination the question is built on.
- **Discipline:** the closing qualification prevents the common overstatement that *dianoia* is a form of opinion.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Aristotle rejects the separation of the Forms, not form itself." Examine this claim.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim is accurate and is the precise formulation an answer on this topic needs.

What he rejects. At *Metaphysics* I.9 Aristotle argues that separated Forms **duplicate** what was to be explained, that "participation" is a **metaphor** rather than an analysis, that a changeless non-spatial entity cannot originate change, and that the theory gives **no account of generation**. The Third Man regress — stated by Plato at *Parmenides* 132a–b and named in Aristotle's reports — shows that self-predication plus non-identity multiplies Forms without end.

What he retains. Form remains the central explanatory principle: it is the **what-it-is-to-be** (*to ti ēn einai*) of the composite, and at *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17 substance is sought as a cause, so "why is this matter a house?" is answered by the form. Species and genus survive as **secondary substances**, and the soul is the form of the living body.

⚠ **Examination.** One qualification is needed. By immanentising form Aristotle inherits Plato's hardest problem in new dress: form must be intelligible and hence universal, yet *Metaphysics* VII (Z).13 denies that any universal is a substance.

Verdict: the rejection is of separation, not of form — and inheriting the universals problem is the price of the repair.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** thesis → what is rejected, as arguments → what is retained → the inherited difficulty → verdict.
- **Evidence:** *Metaphysics* I.9, VII (Z).13, VII (Z).17; *Parmenides* 132a–b; *De Anima* II.1.
- **Precision:** "rejects separated Forms" rather than "rejects forms" is itself a mark-earning formulation.
- **Balance:** naming the Z.13 difficulty prevents the answer from reading as Aristotelian propaganda.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "The *Categories* and *Metaphysics* VII (Z) give different answers because they ask different questions." Critically examine this resolution of Aristotle's account of substance.

Independent model answer

The apparent conflict. In the *Categories* (2a11 ff.) primary substance is the **concrete individual** — "this man", "this horse" (*tode ti*) — and species and genus are secondary substances said of it. In *Metaphysics* VII (Z) substance is the **form or essence** (*to ti ēn einai*), prior to the compound in being, definition and knowledge; matter is rejected as substance at Z.3; and Z.13 states bluntly that **no universal is a substance**, although form looks universal.

The proposed resolution. The *Categories* asks *which things are substances* and answers by a **logical-linguistic** criterion: the ultimate subject of predication. *Metaphysics* Z asks *what the substance of a thing is* and answers by a **causal-explanatory** criterion, reformulated at Z.17 as "why is this matter a house?". Two different questions may have two different answers, and Aristotle insists that being is said in many ways.

Critical examination. ✅ The resolution is the safest available and is textually well grounded. ❓ But it does not dissolve every difficulty. If form is the species-form, Z.13 generates a genuine aporia which Aristotle does not fully resolve — the reading associated with Owen. If form is individual in each substance — the Frede–Patzig line — the tension disappears but the universality science requires becomes harder to secure. Jaeger's developmental reading, that the *Categories* is early and Platonic-adjacent, depends on a chronology that is itself disputed.

⚠️ **Verdict.** The different-questions reading should be **led with**, because it explains Z.3's rejection of bare matter and Z.17's reformulation as steps in one enquiry rather than reversals. It should then be **qualified**: the individual remains what exists primarily, but what accounts for its being that individual is its form, and whether that form is individual or specific is still contested. The change of question is real; it does not by itself settle the universals problem.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** state the conflict sharply → state the resolution → test it against the rival readings → deliver a graded verdict.
- **Evidence:** *Categories* 2a11; *Metaphysics* VII (Z).3, Z.13, Z.17; three named scholarly readings.
- **Analysis:** showing that Z.3 and Z.17 are steps in one enquiry converts description into argument.
- **Discipline:** contested readings are labelled contested — the examiner is testing source honesty as much as content.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "Aristotle's final cause asserts directedness, not design." Discuss with suitable examples, and assess whether teleology survives the objection that it is unscientific.

Independent model answer

The doctrine. The final cause (*telos*) answers "for the sake of what?" and, in purposive and natural-developmental explanation, has a special priority because it states what the process is **for**. In natural substances the formal, efficient and final causes typically **coincide**: the form of oak is both the organising principle of the acorn's development and the end towards which it moves.

Directedness, not design. ⚠️ "Nature does nothing in vain" is a recurring Aristotelian maxim, appearing in *De Caelo*, the *Politics* and *De Partibus Animalium*; it asserts regularity of outcome, not deliberation. Nature is not an artisan with a plan. The example of the artefact — the carpenter making a table for dining — is a **teaching device** drawn from a case where intention really is present; Aristotle's serious cases are organisms, where the directing principle is internal.

Example 1 — the acorn. It reliably becomes an oak and never a cat. That reliability is what the final cause names. *Example 2 — the eye.* Its structure is explained by what seeing requires, not by what a designer intended.

The objection. Post-Galilean physics dispensed with final causes and explained motion by efficient causation and law. If physics needs no *telos*, teleology looks like a superfluous metaphysical overlay.

Assessment. ✅ The objection is decisive **for physics** and much weaker elsewhere. Modern biology retained functional explanation under other names — adaptation, selective advantage, the function of an organ — which is directedness without design. ❓ The residual worry is real: unless directedness is cashed

out independently, "for the sake of" risks describing the outcome and calling it an explanation.

⚠️ **Verdict.** The final cause survives as an account of the directedness of natural processes towards a mature form; it does not survive as a rival to efficient-causal mechanism.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** doctrine → the directedness/design distinction → two examples → the objection → assessment → verdict.
- **Evidence:** the maxim with its works named; acorn and eye; the coincidence of three causes in nature.
- **Balance:** conceding physics while defending biology is a graded verdict, not a hedge.
- **Precision:** flagging the artefact case as a teaching device pre-empts the standard charge of anthropomorphism.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Compare Plato's and Aristotle's metaphysics of form, and evaluate whether Aristotle's immanentism is an advance on Plato's transcendence.

Independent model answer

Frame. Both use the word *eidos*; the dispute is whether form exists apart from its instances. Everything else — causation, generation, knowledge, substance — follows from that difference.

Plato. Forms are eternal, non-material, self-identical universals, independent of sensible particulars and neither in space nor in time. They solve three problems at once: the unity of the many (*hen epi pollōn*), knowledge amid flux, and the objectivity of value. Particulars are what they are by **participation** (*methexis*) or **imitation** (*mimēsis*); the Form is paradigm, the particular imperfect copy. The Sun, Divided Line and Cave (*Republic* VI 507a – VII 517a) form one continuous argument in which degrees of cognitive clarity track degrees of being, with the Good giving the Forms knowability and being and itself said to lie "beyond being" (*epekeina tēs ousias*) at 509b. For Plato true substance (*ousia*) is the universal.

Aristotle. He inverts this. Primary substance is the concrete individual (*tode ti*); species and genus are secondary. Form is the immanent **what-it-is-to-be** (*to ti ēn einai*) of a composite (*synolon*); matter is relative and correlative to form. Change is analysed through subject, form and **privation** (*sterēsis*), explained by the **four causes**, and understood modally as passage from potentiality (*dynamis*) to actuality (*energeia*) — "the actuality of the potential as potential" (*Physics* III.1, 201a10). The system terminates in the Unmoved Mover, pure actuality moving as final cause (*Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7).

The critique. At *Metaphysics* I.9 Aristotle charges Plato with duplicating the explananda, leaving participation a metaphor, rendering Forms causally impotent and offering no account of generation; the Third Man regress at *Parmenides* 132a–b adds a formal difficulty.

Evaluation. ✅ Immanentism advances on three counts: it removes the regress by removing separation, makes form a genuine cause of *this* thing, and makes generation intelligible. ❓ It does not advance on a fourth: Plato's insight that intelligibility may require something beyond the particular is answered rather than refuted, and *Metaphysics* VII (Z).13's denial that any universal is a substance sets Aristotle a difficulty

as deep as the Third Man. ⚠️ Nor is Plato as thin as Aristotle suggests: the *Timaeus* supplies a Demiurge ordering becoming after Forms and a Receptacle in which becoming appears, so the accurate charge is that **separated Forms themselves** explain neither motion nor organisation.

⚠️ **Verdict.** Aristotle transforms Plato's insight rather than erasing it. The dispute is converted into the problem of universals and every later realism–nominalism debate.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** frame the single axis → Plato → Aristotle → the critique → a four-part evaluation → verdict.
- **Evidence density:** *Republic* 507a–517a and 509b; *Parmenides* 132a–b; *Metaphysics* I.9, VII (Z).13, XII (Λ).7; *Physics* III.1; the *Timaeus* qualification.
- **Analysis:** conceding one count on which Aristotle does **not** advance is what makes the verdict graded rather than partisan.
- **Discipline:** the *Timaeus* correction prevents the answer from repeating Aristotle's polemical simplification of his teacher.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Plato's theory of Forms fails not from external attack but from the internal incompatibility of two demands it places on Forms." Critically evaluate.

Independent model answer

The two demands. The theory requires Forms to be **separate** — hence stable, self-identical, timeless, spaceless and therefore knowable — and simultaneously **explanatory** — hence involved in making particulars what they are. The claim under evaluation is that these two requirements pull against each other.

Evidence that the pressure is internal. ✅ Plato states the strongest objections himself. At *Parmenides* 131a–c the participant must receive either the whole Form, which is then separated from itself, or a part, whereupon a divided Form of Smallness would make its participant large. At 132a–b, if the Form of F is itself F and must differ from what it explains, a further Form follows and the regress begins. Neither argument is imported from a rival school; both arise from the theory's own commitments.

Aristotle's contribution. ⚠️ His objections at *Metaphysics* I.9 — duplication, participation as metaphor, causal impotence, no account of generation — largely **systematise** this internal pressure rather than introduce a new one. Stace's report of his barb, that the Ideas are "nothing but eternalized things of nature", is a diagnosis of the duplication that separation makes unavoidable.

The reply available to Plato. ❓ The regress requires self-predication and non-identity; deny self-predication and it weakens sharply, and the whole-or-part dilemma assumes Forms behave like extended bodies, which a spaceless entity does not. Vlastos reads the regress as a strict logical failure, Fine restricts what Plato must concede, and developmental readings see the later dialogues — the *Sophist* on the communion of kinds, the *Timaeus* on the Demiurge and Receptacle — as revision rather than abandonment. Whether the objections are resolved is genuinely contested.

Where the incompatibility bites hardest. ⚠️ Even granting every reply, the **explanatory** demand remains unmet: participation still lacks a non-metaphorical analysis. That is why the deepest objection is not the regress but the causal gap — a relation that cannot be specified cannot explain.

⚠️ **Verdict.** The statement is largely correct but should be graded. The theory does not fail by demonstrated contradiction; it fails to discharge one of the two tasks it set itself, and the failure is internal, since separation was adopted precisely to secure the first task. This is why every later realism about universals keeps the explanatory demand and weakens the separation — which is exactly Aristotle's move, and exactly what leaves him with the universals problem in turn.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** name the two demands → show the pressure is internal → place Aristotle correctly → give Plato's replies → locate the real failure → graded verdict.
- **Evidence density:** *Parmenides* 131a–c and 132a–b; *Metaphysics* I.9; *Sophist* and *Timaeus* as revision evidence; Vlastos and Fine as contested readings; Stace's report.
- **Analysis:** distinguishing "inconsistent" from "explanatorily incomplete" is the discrimination that decides the band.
- **Discipline:** treating the developmental question as open, rather than asserting that Plato abandoned the Forms, is the source-honest position.